The hedgehog metaphor went down well with the commanders: Garbuz would remember it decades later.

"This operation has a single goal: to help the Cuban revolution withstand aggression from the USA," continued Khrushchev. "The political and military leadership of our country, having weighed all the circumstances, sees no other way to prevent an attack by America, which, according to our intelligence, is making intensive preparations for it. Once the rockets are in place, America will grasp that if it wants to make short work of Cuba, it will have to deal with us." Khrushchev was giving the generals an already well-established narrative about Soviet motives for deploying missiles in Cuba. But he also wanted to assure them that he had no intention of provoking war. "If we manage to gain a foothold in Cuba, then the Americans will have to reconcile themselves to what has happened," said Khrushchev. He added that an agreement would be signed with the Cubans, and that he was in constant touch with President Kennedy, hinting that a potential crisis could be resolved peacefully through diplomatic channels.

General Garbuz appreciated what he heard. An experienced commander, he believed that Khrushchev had made his presentation with psychological skill: "On the eve of a difficult and dangerous undertaking, he wanted to instill confidence in the rightness of the idea and serenity in those who would be called upon to carry out extraordinary tasks on the ground," wrote Garbuz later. But Khrushchev was there not only to assure others but also to get assurances himself. "What do you think: can the deployment of our rockets in Cuba be kept secret?" he asked the chief Soviet military adviser in Cuba, General Aleksei Dementiev. "No, Nikita Sergeevich, that is impossible," responded the general after some hesitation. "There's no place there to hide a chicken, let alone a rocket," continued Dementiev in the down-to-earth tone of Khrushchev's comment about the hedgehog. Judging by Garbuz's memoirs, Khrushchev had no ready comeback. If Khrushchev was to stuff a nuclear hedgehog down America's pants, he would have to find a way of hiding chickens more than twenty meters long in the Cuban barnyard or, rather, prevent the Americans from noticing them in plain sight.[1]